

● MEDIUM

● CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

Text Structure and Purpose

10 questions · ~15 min

04

Q1

CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

The following text is adapted from Susan Glaspell's 1912 short story "Out There." An elderly shop owner is looking at a picture that he recently acquired and hopes to sell.

It did seem that the picture failed to fit in with the rest of the shop. A persuasive young fellow who claimed he was closing out his stock let the old man have it for what he called a song. It was only a little out-of-the-way store which subsisted chiefly on the framing of pictures. The old man looked around at his views of the city, his pictures of cats and dogs, his flaming bits of landscape. "Don't belong in here," he fumed.

And yet the old man was secretly proud of his acquisition. There was a hidden dignity in his scowling as he shuffled about pondering the least ridiculous place for the picture.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To reveal the shop owner's conflicted feelings about the new picture
- B. To convey the shop owner's resentment of the person he got the new picture from
- C. To describe the items that the shop owner most highly prizes
- D. To explain differences between the new picture and other pictures in the shop

The following text is from the 1923 poem “Black Finger” by Angelina Weld Grimké, a Black American writer. A cypress is a type of evergreen tree.

I have just seen a most beautiful thing,
Slim and still,
 Against a gold, gold sky,
 A straight black cypress,
Sensitive,
Exquisite,
A black finger
Pointing upwards.
Why, beautiful still finger, are you black?
And why are you pointing upwards?

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. The speaker assesses a natural phenomenon, then questions the accuracy of her assessment.
- B. The speaker describes a distinctive sight in nature, then ponders what meaning to attribute to that sight.
- C. The speaker presents an outdoor scene, then considers a human behavior occurring within that scene.
- D. The speaker examines her surroundings, then speculates about their influence on her emotional state.

By combining Indigenous and classical music, Cree composer and cellist Cris Derksen creates works that reflect the diverse cultural landscape of Canada. For her album *Orchestral Powwow*, Derksen composed new songs in the style of traditional powwow music that were accompanied by classical arrangements played by an orchestra. But where an orchestra would normally follow the directions of a conductor, the musicians on *Orchestral Powwow* are led by the beat of a powwow drum.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To examine how Derksen’s musical compositions blend cultures
- B. To argue that Derksen should be recognized for creating a new style of music
- C. To describe the difficulties Derksen encountered when producing her album
- D. To establish a contrast between Derksen’s classical training and her Cree heritage

Researchers have long hypothesized that woolly mammoths were hunted to extinction in North America by humans using spears with grooved tips known as Clovis points. One anthropologist set out to test this hypothesis. Using a mechanical spear-thrower, he launched spears with Clovis points into mounds of clay—substitutes for the animals’ large bodies. The projectiles generally penetrated only a few inches into the clay, an amount insufficient to have harmed most woolly mammoths. This led the anthropologist to conclude that hunters using spears with Clovis points likely weren’t the principal drivers of the extinction.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To argue for the significance of new findings amid an ongoing debate among researchers
- B. To discuss the advantages and disadvantages of the method used in an experiment
- C. To summarize two competing hypotheses and a major finding associated with each one
- D. To describe an experiment whose results cast doubt on an established hypothesis

Early in the Great Migration of 1910–1970, which involved the mass migration of Black people from the southern to the northern United States, political activist and *Chicago Defender* writer Fannie Barrier Williams was instrumental in helping other Black women establish themselves in the North. Many women hoped for better employment opportunities in the North because, in the South, they faced much competition for domestic employment and men tended to get agricultural work. To aid with this transition, Barrier Williams helped secure job placement in the North for many women before they even began their journey.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To introduce and illustrate Barrier Williams’s integral role in supporting other Black women as their circumstances changed during part of the Great Migration
- B. To establish that Barrier Williams used her professional connections to arrange employment for other Black women, including jobs with the *Chicago Defender*
- C. To demonstrate that the factors that motivated the start of the Great Migration were different for Black women than they were for Black men
- D. To provide an overview of the employment challenges faced by Black women in the agricultural and domestic spheres in the southern United States

Micheline Pesantubbee, a historian and citizen of the Choctaw Nation, has identified a dilemma inherent to research on the status of women in her tribe during the 1600s and 1700s: the primary sources from that era, travel narratives and other accounts by male European colonizers, underestimate the degree of power conferred on Choctaw women by their traditional roles in political, civic, and ceremonial life. Pesantubbee argues that the Choctaw oral tradition and findings from archaeological sites in the tribe's homeland supplement the written record by providing crucial insights into those roles.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It details the shortcomings of certain historical sources, then argues that research should avoid those sources altogether.
- B. It describes a problem that arises in research on a particular topic, then sketches a historian's approach to addressing that problem.
- C. It lists the advantages of a particular research method, then acknowledges a historian's criticism of that method.
- D. It characterizes a particular topic as especially challenging to research, then suggests a related topic for historians to pursue instead.

The following text is adapted from Etsu Inagaki Sugimoto's 1925 memoir *A Daughter of the Samurai*. As a young woman, Sugimoto moved from feudal Japan to the United States.

The standards of my own and my adopted country differed so widely in some ways, and my love for both lands was so sincere, that sometimes I had an odd feeling of standing upon a cloud in space, and gazing with measuring eyes upon two separate worlds. At first I was continually trying to explain, by Japanese standards, all the queer things that came every day before my surprised eyes; for no one seemed to know the origin or significance of even the most familiar customs, nor why they existed and were followed.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A. To convey the narrator's experience of observing and making sense of differences between two cultures she embraces
- B. To establish the narrator's hope of forming connections with new companions by sharing customs she learned as a child
- C. To reveal the narrator's recognition that she is hesitant to ask questions about certain aspects of a culture she is newly encountering
- D. To emphasize the narrator's wonder at discovering that the physical distance between two countries is greater than she had expected

The following text is from the 1924 poem “Cycle” by D’Arcy McNickle, who was a citizen of the Confederated Salish and Kootenai Tribes.

There shall be new roads wending,
A new beating of the drum—
Men’s eyes shall have fresh seeing,
Grey lives reprise their span—
But under the new sun’s being,
Completing what night began,
There’ll be the same backs bending,
The same sad feet shall drum—
When this night finds its ending
And day shall have come.....

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To consider how the repetitiveness inherent in human life can be both rewarding and challenging
- B. To question whether activities completed at one time of day are more memorable than those completed at another time of day
- C. To refute the idea that joy is a more commonly experienced emotion than sadness is
- D. To demonstrate how the experiences of individuals relate to the experiences of their communities

The following text is from Virginia Woolf's 1919 novel *Night and Day*. The text describes a gathering of young artists and intellectuals.

One person after another rose, and, as with an ill-balanced axe, attempted to hew out his conception of art a little more clearly, and sat down with the feeling that, for some reason which he could not grasp, his strokes had gone awry. As they sat down they turned almost invariably to the person sitting next them, and rectified and continued what they had just said in public.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portions in the text as a whole?

- A. To demonstrate individuals' puzzlement over the reputation of a certain artwork
- B. To highlight the physical effort involved in individuals' construction of large-scale works of art
- C. To draw attention to individuals' discontent with the group's conversation about art
- D. To emphasize the extent of individuals' struggles to articulate thoughts on art

The following text is from the 1895 poem “Marshlands” by Emily Pauline Johnson, a Kanienkahagen (Mohawk) writer also known as Tekahionwake.

Among the wild rice in the still lagoon,
In monotone the lizard shrills his tune.
The wild goose, homing, seeks a sheltering,
Where rushes grow, and oozing lichens cling.
Late cranes with heavy wing, and lazy flight,
Sail up the silence with the nearing night.
And like a spirit, swathed in some soft veil,
Steals twilight and its shadows o’er the swale.
Hushed lie the sedges, and the vapours creep,
Thick, grey and humid, while the marshes sleep.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It names animal species found in a place, then names plant species there.
- B. It sketches a setting by presenting a series of images of nature.
- C. It makes an extended comparison of nature to human emotions.
- D. It identifies a location, then refers to a person living there.